had become a beautifully furnished parlor illuminated by those glittering chandeliers.

That was only the beginning: As time went on, virtually every room in the White House felt the touch of Nancy's good taste and her determination to make it the most beautiful house in America.

She did it at no cost to the taxpayers. She went out and raised contributions from Americans who shared her dream of making the White House beautiful again. Once she got started, members of the White House staff began pitching in. A kind of treasure hunt began: Dipping into their memories, veteran staffers told her about pieces of fine furniture, mirrors, paintings, and so forth that had adorned the White House in years past and were gathering dust in nooks and crannies around Washington; Nancy went looking for them and brought the best back. She found a priceless English antique octagon desk, for example, that had been given to the White House when John F. Kennedy was president and was hidden under a layer of dust in a Quonset hut used by the government as a storage unit.

I'll never forget one night when we were having dinner alone and a butler who had worked in the White House for over thirty years put Nancy's meal down in front of her, then turned slightly and looked down the length of the Central Hall. "It's beginning to look like the White House again," he said very quietly.

Some people in the news media criticized Nancy's work on the White House. I'll never understand why. They gave the impression that she was extravagantly spending a fortune of public funds on unnecessary changes and new furnishings when in fact the furnishings were coming out of storage or being paid for by private contributions, not taxpayers.

A classic example was the new set of state china she ordered for the White House. Although it was frequently necessary at state dinners to serve well over a hundred